MOREH NEVUCHIM

Feed Them Too Fast and They Drown: The Motivation Behind Matter & Man

Given Tuesday 15 September 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim I:17

Sefer: Moreh Nevuchim (Rambam), Chelek Aleph — Rabbi Chaim Makbili's Hebrew edition / Sefaria

Chapter: I:17 — **the need to keep esoteric teachings hidden**, and **החומר, הצורה וההעדר** (matter, form and privation)

Date: First shiur of 5787, in the days after Rosh Hashanah — **תזכו לשנים רבות נעימות וטובות**

Topic: Why even scientific matters must be taught in metaphor; the three principles of all generated and perishing things; why privation drives all change; how Hashem is the *tzur* above the *tzurah*; and why the Rambam must ration what he teaches

Schedule note: Chapter 18 was planned for this evening but was not reached — Chapter 17 needed the full hour. Next shiur: **Chapters 18 (karav/nigash — drawing near), 19 (maleh — filling) and 20 (ram — exalted)**, all three of which are relatively easy and should fit in one hour. That shiur will either be **next Tuesday 8:00pm or after Sukkot** — to be confirmed on the group. **No shiur on Chol HaMoed**; we resume after Sukkot regardless.

The Rabbi's request: this is a very important chapter and not an easy one. Those present and those listening to the recording should **review it** — go over the notes, listen again — before we move on.

Recap — Chapter 16: Tzur

We reviewed the whole of Section 1 last time and then learned **Chapter 16**, which is directly relevant here. *Tzur* can mean a boulder, a sharp flint, or a quarry — but the purpose of the chapter is the **figurative** meaning: **the source from which something originates**. Hence Yeshayahu's **הביטו אל צור חצבתם** — look to where you come from, Avraham and Sarah, and copy their ways.

Theologically: when *tzur* is used of HaKadosh Baruch Hu it always means **the ultimate source and cause of all existence**, never a physical rock. And so **ונצבת על הצור** — combining *nitzav* (permanence, from the earlier chapters) with *tzur* — means: **firmly and constantly contemplate Hashem as the source of all being**, and thereby attain a higher knowledge of Him.

Where Chapter 17 Sits

Chapter 16 was *tzur*. Chapter 18 is *karav* and *nigash* — drawing near. Chapter 19 is *maleh*, Chapter 20 is *ram* — more of the terms we have been working through all along. **Chapter 17**

does something completely different: it discusses the importance of **keeping esoteric teachings hidden from the masses**.

It looks random and out of place. **It is not** — but we will read the chapter first, and only then return to the question of the sequence. The chapter is not complex; it simply requires laying out a few Aristotelian concepts.

The Chapter — Three Paragraphs

Paragraph One — Even Science Must Be Veiled

אל תחשוב שרק מדעי האלוהות נמנעו מן ההמון, אלא גם רוב מדעי הטבע

Do not think that only the divine sciences are withheld from the masses — **most of natural science** is too.

וכבר אמרתי לך דברי חז"ל: ולא במעשה בראשית בשניים

As we learned in the Introduction, the Mishnah in Chagigah teaches that even **Ma'aseh Bereishit** — the deep scientific matters, the building blocks of existence — may not be taught even to two people at once, but only one to one.

ודבר זה אינו רק בדת שלנו, אלא גם בדת הפילוסופים

And this is not only our religion's position — **the philosophers held the same**: certain concepts must be kept from the masses.

חכמי האומות בימי קדם היו מסבירים את הדיונים על הראשית ומדברים עליהם בחידות

The sages of the nations in ancient times explained discussions of first principles **in riddles**.

ואפלטון ומי שקדם לו היו מכנים את החומר נקבה ואת הצורה זכר

Plato and his predecessors called **matter female** and **form male** — metaphors, not plain statement.

Reminder: chomer and tzurah

Everything in this universe, in Aristotelian and Platonic thought, is composed of **chomer** (matter) and **tzurah** (form). Take a chair: it is made of matter, but what makes it *a chair* is that it has the **form** of a chair. Matter plus form together produce the composite object. **Everything physical is a composite of the two.**

Why male and female? Because **the form acts upon the matter**, as the male acts upon the female. Think of the conception of a child: a tiny drop from the man, processed over nine months by the woman, produces a child. The man's contribution is the acting, forming principle — the *tzurah*; the woman is the substance that receives and develops it — the *chomer*. *(We went into this at length in **Chapter 6** with ish and ishah, and these themes recur throughout the book.)*

The Rambam's point in this paragraph

Over the last many chapters we have been explaining terms whose plain sense is not their meaning — *kisei* is a throne but means **majesty**; *shamayim* is heaven but means **permanence and endurance**. Why does the Tanach speak this way instead of saying it outright?

Because lofty ideas revealed outright are dangerous — injurious to someone not ready for them. And what the Rambam adds here is that this is true **not only of theology but of science**: even the philosophers, when speaking of the building blocks of existence, wrapped them in metaphor.

A parenthesis on Plato. This is the **first time the Rambam names Plato** in the Moreh. He alluded to **Aristotle** earlier, in Chapter 5 — the caution required in approaching the burning bush — without naming him, and he will cite Aristotle many times throughout the book. **Plato appears far less.** He will be discussed at length in **Section 2**, where we treat the origin of all existence — creation *ex nihilo* versus creation from pre-existing matter. (Plato was, of course, Aristotle's teacher.)

Paragraph Two — The Three Principles

This is the key paragraph, and the one that needs explaining.

יודע אתה שראשיות הנמצאים ההווים ונפסדים שלוש: החומר, והצורה, וההעדר המיוחד המחובר עמו תמיד

The principles of all things that **come into being and perish** are three: matter, form, and **the particular privation that is always joined to matter**.

Everything material has a beginning and an end — even if that span is thousands or millions of years. Until now we have spoken of two principles, *chomer* and *tzurah*. Now a third: **הֶעְדֵּר** — deficiency, lack, absence; in the English editions, **privation**.

לולי חיבורו של ההעדר אליו — לא היה מקבל צורה

Were privation not joined to matter, **matter would never receive a form** at all.

ומהבחינה הזאת ההעדר נמנה עם הראשיות

And in that respect privation is **counted among the principles**.

עם קבלת הצורה יבטל אותו ההעדר — כלומר העדר הצורה שקיבל החומר — ויתחבר לו העדר אחר. וכן לעולם, כפי שידוע במדעי הטבע.

When the form is received, **that** privation is annulled — and **a new privation attaches** in its place. **And so on forever**, as is known in natural science.

The Aristotelian background

Principle 1: things that are perfect do not change. This is why God does not change — He is perfect. *(This is also, incidentally, the root of Aristotle's conclusion that the universe is eternal and uncreated: for there to be an act of creation there must be an imperfection, a deficiency. We will treat the Rambam's arguments against the eternity of the universe at length in* ***Section 2*** *— mentioned here only as a hakdamah. Aristotle was wrong, as we now know from the Big Bang; but until the 1920s–60s his was the most widely held view, because as a general rule the laws of the universe do not change: things reproduce and perish, but the rules of physics hold constant, and in that sense they are "perfect.")*

Principle 2: everything is a composite of chomer and tzurah. There is no pure matter and no pure form in this world.

The inference: if perfect things do not change, and all there were was matter and form, **nothing would ever change** — matter and form would simply sit there. So **there must be a third ingredient instigating every change** — and that ingredient must be a **lack**, a deficiency, a privation. **Because it is precisely the absence of perfection that produces change.**

So: when matter "senses" a *he'eder*, it **calls upon itself a further form** to attach to it, transforming it into something else and annulling that deficiency.

Four illustrations

1. The unmusical man (Aristotle's kind of example). Take a person who has never encountered music — cannot play violin, trumpet, shofar, trombone. He goes to a teacher and after some years can play the violin.

Element	In the analogy
Chomer (matter)	The human being — the unmusical man
Tzurah (form)	Musicality — the concept of violin-playing; nothing material about it
He'eder (privation)	"I don't know how to play the violin"

He passes a wedding, sees someone playing, and feels the lack — **and that lack is what drives him to the teacher**. Without it he would simply have remained as he was. Then he masters the violin, grade nine, the lot — the deficiency is filled. **And the next day he goes to another wedding, hears a trumpet, and a new deficiency kicks in:** *I can play violin, but I can't play trumpet.* **וכן לעולם.**

2. The bronze. A chunk of bronze is already matter with some (haphazard) form. The deficiency in its being a mere chunk is what drives it to be made into a **statue**. And then: *lovely — but it could be made finer still.*

3. The Rambam's own analogy (which he gives later in the Moreh, Section 3): **the adulterous woman.** A single woman seeks marriage — there is a form, the form of a couple, a unit. Married, she is matter joined to form. But the promiscuous woman says *I want to taste something else* — and finds a second man; the deficiency satisfied, a third is now wanted. And so on. *(The reason the analogy runs this way round — woman as the seeker — is that **chomer is the female** principle, and it is matter that bears the privation and reaches for new form.)*

The Rabbi's aside (his own, offered briefly and left for us to develop): this explains a great deal of what one sees in the world today. **When everything is possible and everything has been tried, one must reach for ever more obscure things** — because there is always another absence demanding to be filled.

4. A participant's example — the acorn. An acorn has both form and substance. Planted, it has a deficiency: it needs to become a tree. It becomes a sapling — still not a full oak, so a further deficiency, and it grows and grows. **The Rabbi: a fantastic example; it fits perfectly.** *(And ultimately it dies — why things die is a separate question, but without deficiency it would simply persist unchanged forever, which it cannot.)*

Paragraph Three — All The More So For Us

ואם אלה שאין להם נזק בהעברה השתמשו במונחים מושאלים ונקטו דימויים וטרחו בלימוד — כל שכן אנחנו מקבלי התורה, שמוטלת החובה עלינו לא לומר בפירוש דבר שקשה להמון להבינו, או שיבינו את אמיתת העניין באופן שונה ממה שצריך ללמד. דע זאת גם כן.

If **they** — whose subject matter carries no great danger in transmission — nonetheless used borrowed terms, resorted to similes, and laboured over how to teach, **how much more so we who received the Torah**. We are **obliged** not to state plainly what the masses will find hard, or what they will understand differently from how it ought to be taught. **Know this too.**

The Two Questions

Read plainly, the chapter's purpose is Paragraphs 1 and 3: **esoteric matters must be kept hidden, in science as in Torah.** Which leaves two problems:

1. **Why is this chapter here at all**, between *tzur* (16) and *karav/nigash* (18)?
2. **Why is Paragraph Two here?** Paragraphs 1 and 3 make the point perfectly well on their own. Why introduce the whole business of privation?

The class's suggestions (all taken as partial): **Doron** — perhaps it is really a preface to the entire project of explaining terms, and so belongs at Chapter 1 or 2; and Paragraph 2 may simply be an **example** of a lofty idea that must be handled carefully — after all, it took us half an hour. **Another participant** — Paragraph 2 is "the motivation of matter," an illustration of why such things need veiling. **The Rabbi:** both are acceptable as far as they go, **but incomplete — there is much more going on here.**

A further exchange: one participant suggested *tzurah* be understood as "a creative force." **Corrected:** *tzurah* is **form**, nothing more. Another raised the difficulty of reconciling any of this with current scientific knowledge. **The Rabbi:** whether this science is true today is **not the point of the chapter**; this is what the Rambam, following Aristotle and Plato, believed, and our task is to understand what he is doing with it.

Answer to Question One — Hashem Is the *Tzur* of the *Tzurah*

*(The Rabbi: "I'm surprised nobody picked up on it — I've been banging on about **tzurah**, and Chapter 16 was about **tzur**." He credits this to **Korobkin**, whom he has quoted before, though he cannot recall Korobkin's own source.)*

צור — the source and origin of all existence (Chapter 16). **צורה** — form.

Now notice a grammatical oddity. **In Plato's, Aristotle's and the Rambam's thought, form is the *male* principle** — it acts upon matter. **Yet *tzurah* is a feminine noun.** Any noun ending in *heh* is feminine — with exactly **one exception in biblical Hebrew: לילה** (hence *laylah tov*, not *laylah tovah*).

Why should form be a feminine noun? Because **something acts even upon form.** Who is the ultimate male, the ultimate actor? **HaKadosh Baruch Hu.** He is **the *tzur* of the *tzurah*** — above form, above matter, above privation. **Relative to Him, even form is feminine**, in that it receives its instruction from Him.

And that is the continuation from Chapter 16. This is the difference between studying science and studying science **with HaKadosh Baruch Hu**: yes, there is *chomer*, there is *tzurah*, there is *he'eder* — **but above all of it is Hashem, directing it, causing form to combine with matter and privation and so producing all that exists.** Having established in Chapter 16 that Hashem is the origin of all being, the Rambam now shows **how that origin stands over the physical structure of the world**.

Answer to Question Two — Privation Applied to Human Beings

Paragraph Two is here because the Rambam is describing *us*.

First, a refinement of Chapter 6. Generally the male is *tzurah* and the female *chomer* — but **a human being can be either, depending on context**. The Rabbi teaching the class is *tzurah*, and everyone listening — men included — is *chomer*; later this evening or tomorrow the roles reverse. A woman teaching a room of boys is the *tzurah* and they are the *chomer*. **It shifts constantly.**

Either way, the point stands: **human beings, like matter, are constantly hungry to fill a deficiency.**

Materially

The natural state of a human being is to want **more**. I have money, I want more money; power, more power; food, more food. This is the meaning of Shlomo HaMelech's **אוהב כסף לא ישבע כסף** — and, as **Rabbeinu Avraham makes explicit in HaMaspik Chapter 9** (which we learn on Monday nights, this coming week, on *histapkut* — contentment), **this is not specifically about money; money is an example of all material matter.**

Map it: I am the *chomer*, the intellectual construct of "being rich" — the holidays, the freedom, whatever your mental image is — is the *tzurah*; and the *he'eder* attaches to me and says **"more."** My target: £X by the end of the year. I make it. **The deficiency is annulled — and instantly a new one kicks in.** I wanted this food; I've had it, now the next; this wine, then the next. **There is no end.** *(This, incidentally, is precisely why **histapkut is such a hard character trait**.)*

Intellectually — and this is the Rambam's real move

Beyond material things, **the same structure governs intellect and identity**. The Rambam writes explicitly later in the Moreh that a person **naturally wants to develop himself intellectually**. Nobody wants to stagnate; we all have a drive to move forward.

And when a person does not respond to that *he'eder* — that is what the Rambam calls *ra*, bad. He says it **specifically about the failure of intellectual development**: a person who does not recognize that the privation is acting upon him, and ignores it, **is bad**.

Therefore — the Rambam's own teaching method

This is why Paragraph Two sits between Paragraphs One and Three. The Rambam is saying: *I must be careful how much I give you, because the more I feed you, the hungrier you become.*

The thirst analogy. You are the *chomer*, water is the *tzurah*; thirst is the *he'eder*. Fill it — but **fill it too fast and a person can die from over-drinking.**

The fast-day analogy. Think of last night, after the fast. We are all famished — and what do most of us do? **Overeat**, and then lie awake with stomach ache.

That is exactly the danger in teaching. "I am giving you intellect and information throughout this book," says the Rambam in effect. **"I must give it to you in a way that respects these three ingredients — in order, slowly, esoterically — or I will drown you."** The *he'eder* has to come **in sequence**: fill one, then the next, then the next. **Lay the whole table out at once and the student is harmed.**

Summary — Chapter 17

The Rambam teaches that **profound theological *and scientific* ideas must sometimes be conveyed through metaphor**, because revealing them directly to one who is not ready is **harmful** — a point he makes at the very start of the chapter. He then sets out that **physical change occurs when matter acquires form in response to a deficiency**, and that once that deficiency is filled **another immediately emerges** — endlessly. He applies this to human beings, who are driven to seek more **both materially and intellectually**. And therefore: **"I must be careful how much knowledge I reveal, and to whom"** — because overfeeding an appetite that by its nature can never be satisfied is dangerous. The structure of the chapter is the argument: Paragraph One establishes the practice, Paragraph Two supplies the reason it is necessary, Paragraph Three drives it home *kal vachomer* for those who received the Torah. And the placement after Chapter 16 is no accident: **Hashem is the *tzur* of the *tzurah*** — the source standing above matter, form and privation alike.

Q&A

Mark: Without privation, could there be free will? — **The Rabbi:** it likely does tie in. With only *chomer* and *tzurah* we would be **angelic** — what we are at birth is what we would remain. And it is not only free will that would go: **there would be no growth at all** — our bodies would not develop, we would be born a baby and stay a baby. *(An angel simply **is** what it is; there is no growing.)*

Jonathan: Is the Rambam effectively offering a **synthesis** — absorbing the Aristotelian structure of form and substance and superimposing a divine edifice upon it, reconciling the scientific knowledge of his day with divine involvement? With the ultimate *tzurah* as the divine intellect continually inspiring form to act upon matter — so that existence is not a stable situation but an **inherently unstable one, divinely programmed with a drive toward improvement**? — **The Rabbi: 100%, exactly correct.** And it ties directly to what those at the Monday night shiurim learned in **HaMaspik Chapter 8 (bitachon)**, just before the summer break: **Rabbeinu Avraham on the importance of learning science and then placing Hashem on top of it** — the whole edifice, and then Hashem above it. That is precisely what is happening here.

A participant: There seems to be an **echo of the burning bush** in this chapter — Hashem being approached with caution, and this whole area likewise being approached with caution. — **The Rabbi: correct, it links very well with Chapter 5.**

Philip raised the question of **teshuvah** in relation to all this — deferred, since the discussion at that point was still confined to matter rather than human beings. *(The human application above is the beginning of the answer; the Rabbi noted separately that a person working on himself against his natural state is a different matter — "that's teshuvah, let's leave that.")*

Coming Up

- **Chapters 18, 19 and 20** — *karav* and *nigash* (drawing near), *maleh* (filling), *ram* (exalted). All relatively easy; all three should fit in one hour.
- That shiur will be **either next Tuesday 8:00pm or after Sukkot** — watch the group. **No shiur on Chol HaMoed.**
- **Review Chapter 17** before then.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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